

NOVEMBER 20, 1953

French airborne troops establish a base at Dien Bien Phu, near the border of Vietnam and Laos.



Indochina War Medal, first awarded in 1953

MARCH 13, 1954

The garrison at Dien Bien Phu comes under attack from Viet Minh infantry and artillery surrounding the base.

APRIL 24, 1954

The Geneva Conference opens with the goal of creating peace in Korea and Indochina.

MAY 7, 1954

Dien Bien Phu falls to the Viet Minh after eight weeks of fighting—a shattering blow to French morale.

JUNE 16, 1954

Ngo Dinh Diem becomes prime minister of Vietnam, under the presidency of former emperor Bao Dai.

JULY 21, 1954

The Geneva Accords divide Vietnam at the 17th parallel, with the Viet Minh controlling the North and the State of Vietnam controlling the South.